9 Indian National Movement – Phase III (1939-1947)

Second World War and India: Impacts

Germany attacked Poland on September 1, 1939. then immediately on September 3, 1939, Britain declared war aginst Germany and also declared India support for war without Consulting Indian opinion.

Indians' Attitude Towards War:

- **Possibility of freedom:** Starting a powerful movement against the British and resisting British attempts to gather India's resources for the war.
- **Capitalise on Britain's problems:** However, political organisations like the Hindu Mahasabha and the Muslim League backed the British war effort.
- **Fascism as a greater threat to mank ind:** Fascism was seen as posing a more significant menace to humanity, leading to a desire to aid Britain in the War conditionally.

August Offer (1940)

Major political organisations had to join forces in order to secure the long-term, steady, and continuous support of Indians towards the war effort. **On August 8, 1940**, Viceroy of India Lord Linlithgow spoke on behalf of the British Parliament, and his remarks became known as the **"August Offer."**

Objectives:

- **Dominion Status:** It proposed Dominion status as India's end goal.
- **Democratic Government:** No new form of government would be implemented without the support of minorities in politics and religion.
- **Constituent Assembly:** It would be established after the war to decide India's constitutional future.
- **Expand the Viceroy Executive Council:** To include a specific number of Indian political representatives.

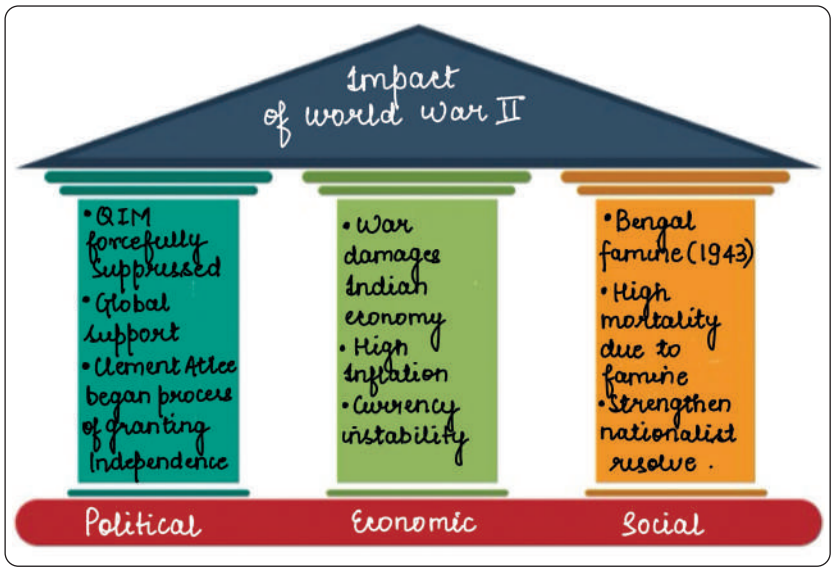

Fig. 9.1: Impact of World War II
Diagram Type: *Pillar*

Response from Different Sections:

- **Congress:** They turned down the offer because they said it was yet another British effort to "deny India her natural right of complete national freedom."
- **Muslim League:** Although it referred to the Offer as "progress," it took issue with the British for not consulting Indian political parties over the Viceroy's council's projected enlargement.
- **Hindu Mahasabha:** This organisation, which asserted to speak for Hindu interests, was receptive to the Offer and even swiftly proposed some of its members for the Viceroy's council.

Individual Satyagraha (1940) and its Significance

Gandhiji and the Congress wanted to avoid disrupting the War effort, which a mass movement could have done. Thus, they restricted the movement to individual involvement. Vinoba Bhave was the first to offer satyagraha, followed by Nehru. By May 1941, about 25,000 people had been arrested for participating in the satyagraha, demonstrating individual commitment to nonviolence and civil disobedience while maintaining pressure on the British .

Objectives

- To demonstrate that nationalist patience was not the result of weakness.

- To convey the sentiment that people do not care about the war and have distinguished between Nazism and the dual autocracy that ruled India.
- To offer the government a second chance to peacefully accept the demands of the congress.
- The Satyagrahi would march towards Delhi and repeat the action in villages if the government does not detain them **(Delhi Chalo Movement)**.

Significance

- **Defining Mindset:** It contributed to defining the mindset behind India's struggle for independence.
- **Legitimacy:** Individuals were able to prove the legitimacy of their cause and the intensity of their commitment by respectfully and nonviolently requesting independence.
- **Sense of Purpose:** It empowered them and gave them a sense of purpose, enabling them to take charge of their own fate and participate in the greater struggle for liberation.

Outcome

- **Constraints of Gandhiji:** The movement faced limitations due to Gandhiji's constraints, resulting in limited achievements.
- **Reluctance in Bihar:** In Bihar, individuals chosen to participate in Satyagraha hesitated to resign from their positions in municipal bodies.
- **Impact on Cripps Proposal:** This Satyagraha led to the introduction of the Cripps Proposal, which notably diverged from the August offer by incorporating provisions for the Constituent Assembly and the option for any Province to withdraw, ultimately influencing the trajectory towards India's partition.

Cripps Mission (1942): Significance and Consequences

Congress intended to take **advantage of the circumstance** by stepping up its efforts in the pursuit of independence In March, 1942, a mission headed by Stafford Cripps was sent to India to gain Indian support for the war.

Objective

- To achieve a **Hindu-Muslim agreement on a constitutional arrangement** and persuade the Indians to delay their struggle until after the Second World War.

Proposals

- **Dominion Status:** India would be given dominion status with total internal and external autonomy after the war was over.
- **Constituent Assembly for New Constitution:** A Constituent Assembly would be established following the war and given the authority to write India's new constitution.
  - The provincial assemblies were supposed to elect the assembly members using a proportional representation system.
- **Option to Opt Out:** The provinces would have the option to opt out of the proposed Union if they disagreed with the new constitution.
- **Interim Government during War:** An interim government made up of various Indian political parties would be established throughout the war.

Significance

- **Constitution Formation:** The responsibility for drafting the constitution was to be solely entrusted to Indian authorities.
- **Detailed Plan for Constituent Assembly:** A comprehensive proposal was presented regarding the establishment and functioning of the constituent assembly.
- **Provincial Autonomy:** Each province had the option to devise its own constitution, laying the groundwork for India's eventual partition.
- **Increased Indian Administration:** A significant portion of administrative control was delegated to Indian officials during this period.
- **Freedom to Exit Commonwealth:** India was granted the freedom to exit the Commonwealth if it achieved independence.

Causes of Failure

- **Incapacity of Cripps:** The impasse was made worse by Cripps' inability to stray from the Draft Declaration and his rigid "take it or leave it" stance.
- **Expansion of the executive council only:** Cripps had before used the terms "cabinet" and "national government," but he later clarified that he had merely intended to refer to an increase in the executive council.
- **Procedure for accession lacked clarity:** Secession was to be decided by a resolution passed by the legislature with a 60% majority.
- **Treaty transferring power:** Furthermore, it was unclear who would implement and interpret the treaty transferring power.

Churchillian Negativism	Crippsian Constructiveness
❖ He acknowledged the necessity to eventually allow India self-governance, but sought to put it off as long as possible. ❖ Churchill publicly stated, "I have not become the King's First Minister in order to preside over the liquidation of the British Empire."	❖ Sir Stanford Cripps was a longtime supporter of Indian Independence and a member of the War Council for the Labour Party. ❖ Clement Attlee and Nehru agreed to the notion of electing the Indian Constituent Assembly using the universal adult franchise during their 1938 meeting.

Quit India (1942) or August Kranti

Events Leading to Quit India Movement (UPSC 2024)

- **Failure of the Cripps Mission (1942):** The Cripps Mission offered dominion status after World War II, but it failed to satisfy Indian demands for immediate self-rule, leading to widespread disappointment.
- **Impact of World War II:** India was dragged into the war without consent. Economic hardships, inflation, and forced recruitment created public resentment.
- **Growing Discontent and Repression:** Harsh wartime measures, press censorship, and lack of civil liberties created a climate of unrest.
- **Inspirations from Global Struggles:** The weakening of colonial powers during WWII and rising anti-colonial sentiments worldwide inspired Indian leaders to intensify the struggle.
- **Radicalization of the Congress:** Leaders like Gandhi, Nehru, and Patel felt that constitutional methods had failed, and it was time for mass civil disobedience.
- **Gandhiji's Call for Immediate Action:** Gandhiji's famous slogan "Do or Die" galvanized people for a decisive and united national struggle.

Resolution for Complete Independence (Quit India Resolution)

- The CWC meeting held on July 14, 1942, in Wardha, supported the notion of a fight and passed Quit India Resolution calling for total independence from the British government and Quit India Resolution was Ratified at the Congress meeting at Gowalia Tank, Bombay, on August, 8, 1942.

Results of Movement

- **Widespread Participation and Unrest:** The movement witnessed massive involvement from students, workers, and peasants, including spontaneous violence in some regions.
- **Brutal Repression by the British:** The government responded with mass arrests, public lathi-charges, and shoot-at-sight orders. Major leaders were jailed, including Gandhi.
- **Underground Resistance:** With top leadership in prison, underground networks led by leaders like Jayaprakash Narayan and Ram Manohar Lohia kept the movement alive.
- **Weakened British Control:** The British realized maintaining their rule was becoming increasingly difficult, especially post-war.
- **Shift in British Policy:** The movement marked a turning point, compelling Britain to consider serious negotiations, leading eventually to the Cabinet Mission and Indian independence.
- **Rise in Nationalist Spirit:** Though suppressed, it created a psychological and political environment that made British withdrawal inevitable.

Significance

- **Gandhi's Centrality:** Gandhi's twenty-one-day fast helped him regain his position as the movement's symbolic leader.
- **Independence a priority:** It put the demand for independence at the top of the national movement's immediate priority list.
- **Manner of Transfer:** Future discussions exclusively on the manner of the transfer of power with the British government are permitted.
- **Freedom became evident:** Freedom was no longer up for negotiation. And after the War, this became abundantly evident.
- **Constructive Work:** The primary focus of Congress activity shifted to constructive work, with a focus on reorganising the legislative branch.

How Did the Quit India Movement Differ From Other Gandhian Movements?

- **Historical Interpretations:** Both official and unofficial historical narratives debate the spontaneity versus organization and the levels of violence and non-violence in the Quit India Movement.
- **Departure from Nonviolence:** The movement saw a departure from Gandhian principles of nonviolent resistance, with individuals devising their own strategies for resistance.

- **Involvement of Key Figures:** Prominent figures such as Rammanohar Lohia, Jayaprakash Narayan, Aruna Asaf Ali, Usha Mehta, Biju Patnaik, Chhotubhai Puranik, Achyut Patwardhan, Sucheta Kripalani, and R.P. Goenka were actively involved.
- **Rural Support:** The movement garnered significant support from rural masses across regions like Bombay, Andhra, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Gujarat, Orissa, Karnataka, and Bengal.
- **Emergence of Parallel Governments:** Chitu Pandey in Ballia, Tamluk Jatiya Sarkar in Bengal, and Satara in Maharashtra witnessed the establishment of parallel governance structures during the movement.
- **Challenge to State Authority:** Unlike traditional Satyagraha, the movement emphasized a "fight to the finish" approach, posing a significant challenge to the government machinery.
- **Considered the Most Un-Gandhian Movement:** Gandhi's belief in the willingness of citizens to sacrifice for the nation stood in contrast to the confrontational nature of the Quit India Movement, earning it the reputation of being the most un-Gandhian of all movements.

Was Quit India Movement a spontaneous outburst, or an organized rebellion?

Spontaneous	Organized
❖ An enormous wave of mob rage that nationalist legends refer to as the "August Revolution" followed the arrest of the top leadership. ❖ Since the whole high echelon of the Congress leadership was already in jail before it started, it was violent and completely out of control from the start.	❖ The history of the Quit India campaign reveals that it was more than just an unprepared populace's impetuous reaction.
❖ Everyone was taken aback by the movement's unusually high intensity. It was "by far the most serious rebellion since 1857," according to Viceroy Linlithgow. ❖ The Quit India campaign, according to historians like F. G. Hutchins, was a "spontaneous revolution" that resulted from the Congress's exhortation for the populace to "fight to the finish."	❖ The preceding two decades of mass mobilisation, which had recently been led by a number of connected and affiliated organisations of the Congress, had been conducted on a far more radical tone and had already laid the foundation for such a conflagration. ❖ Before the 9th of August, the Congress leaders had created a twelve-point agenda that included both additional plans and the typical Gandhian satyagraha techniques.

British power in India was not overthrown by the Quit India Movement. However, this was one movement that showed the strength and fortitude of various Indian groups to fight the haughtiness of the imperial authority and the elitism of the Indian political class.

C R Formula or Rajaji Formula and Gandhi -Jinnah Talks (1944)

C. Rajagopalachari came up with the Rajagopalachari formula (also known as the C. R. formula or Rajaji formula) to break the political impasse between the All India Muslim League and the Indian National Congress on the independence of British India.

Main Points of the Formula:

- Muslim League will support the independence demand made by Congress.
- League to work with Congress to build a temporary national government.
- After the war, a poll was held to determine whether or not the inhabitants of the Muslim-majority regions of North West and North East India should establish their own sovereign state.
- If the partition is accepted, a common agreement will be created to protect communications, trade, and defence.
- The aforementioned conditions would only apply if England gave India complete authority.

Gandhi-Jinnah Talks and Jinnah's Objection

- Gandhi suggested conversations with Jinnah based on his two-nation idea after being released from prison. The CR formula served as the framework for the negotiations.
- Gandhi offered Jinnah the CR formula as a suggestion. Nevertheless, after two weeks of discussions, the Gandhi-Jinnah meetings ended in failure.
- **Gandhi's View:** He believed that the talks failed because of fundamentally different worldviews.
- **Jinnah's Objection:**
  - Jinnah wished for the **two-nation doctrine to be accepted** by the Congress.
  - He demanded that the **plebiscite only allow votes from North West and North East Muslims,** not from the full population.

- Jinnah thought that the **League acted as the voice of all Muslims** and that the adult franchise called for by the formula was unnecessary.

- In the north-west, **Sind, Baluchistan, the North-West Frontier Province, and Punjab,** and in the north-east, **Assam and Bengal,** Jinnah had staked a claim for British Indian Provinces that were at the time considered to have a majority Muslim population.

Shimla Conference and Wavell Plan (1945)

Background:

- Lord Wavell, the new Governor-General who had succeeded Lord Linlithgow, tried to end the impasse.
- Wavell claimed that Congress and its allies needed to refocus their resources away from agitation and towards **"some more profitable channel, namely, dealing with the administrative problems of India and trying to solve the constitutional problems."**

Schemes under the Plan:

- **Restructuring of Governor-General's Executive Council:** The Executive Council of the Governor-General was to undergo renovation while the formulation of a new constitution was underway.
- **Balanced Representation:** The Council was to include equal numbers of Muslims and Hindus, ensuring balanced representation of major ethnic groups.
- **Maintenance of Governor-General's Veto:** While the Governor-General's veto power would remain intact, it was expected to be used sparingly.
- **Delegation of External Affairs:** Control over external affairs was to be transferred from the Governor-General to an Indian council member.
- **Formation of Executive Council:** A Conference of Representatives appointed by the Viceroy was to convene to secure joint or separate lists of deserving individuals from various party leaders for the new Executive Council.
- **Anticipation of Provincial Minister Resumption:** It was anticipated that provincial ministers would resume their offices and form a coalition within the provinces.

Shimla Conference:

- **To Discuss Wavell Plan:** A convention of 21 Indian political figures was summoned to Shimla, the summer capital of the British Government, to debate the Wavell Plan's provisions.
- **No Consensus:** However, discussions were stuck when it came to choosing Muslim delegates.
  - It was therefore claimed that Congress lacked the authority to appoint any Muslims to the Executive Council.
  - Jinnah also insisted that there be a clause stating that a vote can only be approved by two-thirds of members in the event of a vote being divided and a Muslim member objecting.
  - The Muslim league did not relent and Wavell dropped the plan.
- **Negotiation Failed:** Lord Wavell concluded the Conference by claiming that the negotiations had failed. The summit was ruined as a result, possibly ending India's chances of becoming a united, independent nation.

India National Army (INA) or Azad Hind Fauj and INA Trials: Significance

Mohan Singh founded the India National Army (INA), also known as Azad Hind Fauj, for the first time in 1942. On October 21, 1943, during the Second World War, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose resurrected it to ensure India's complete independence from the British Raj.

Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose

- **Post Tripuri Crisis (1938-1939):** As we saw in the chapter before, Subhas Bose established the Forward Bloc within the Congress to promote communist and socialist activities following the **"Tripuri crisis".**
- **The Daring Escape**: Detained in July 1940 under the "Defence of India Act", was placed under home arrest. In a **"daunting escape"** from Calcutta, to cross India from the east to the northwest, through Kabul into the Soviet Union, and ultimately to Berlin.
- **Provisional Government of Free India**: It was established by Subhas Bose in October 1943, and it was eventually acknowledged by Japan and eight other nations.
- **Delhi Chalo**: The provisional government declared war on Great Britain after Subhas issued his well-known call, **"Delhi Chalo."**
- **Surrender after Nuclear attack**: After the US dropped atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki (in August 1945), Japan was compelled to surrender, and the INA was left to fight its way back under difficult circumstances.

Post Surrender of INA:

- The **20,000 INA soldiers** who surrendered were questioned before being returned to India.
  - **"Greys" and "Whites,":** The ones among them who seemed to have been "misled" by Japanese and INA propaganda. They were either released or rehired into the army.
  - **"Blacks":** Others, who were more devoted to the cause, were classified as "Blacks" and subjected to court martial.
- **There were eleven trials in total:** The most well-known one took place at Delhi's Red Fort and involved the three INA commanders, P. K. Sehgal, G. S. Dhillon, and Shah Nawaz Khan. Treason, murder, and accessory to murder charges were brought against Sehgal, Dhillon, and Khan.
- **Fundamental Idea behind Public Trial:** The purpose of the government's public trial was to brutally punish army officers for treason and inform the people of the "horrors" inflicted by INA.

Significance:

- **Tricolor on Indian Soil:** One of the INA Brigades, accompanied by the Japanese army, advanced to the Indian border, where the Indian flag was hoisted for the first time in Kohima, Nagaland, in March 1944.
- **Political Impact:** INA's activities had a profound impact on the political landscape of India during that period.
- **Surge of Revolution:** The nation witnessed a surge of revolutionary fervor as tales of INA's extraordinary bravery and sacrifices spread among the Indian populace following the battle.
- **Heightened Patriotism:** The British government observed a marked increase in Indian patriotism, surpassing their allegiance to the colonial rulers.
- **Inspirational Vision of Independence:** Despite its embrace of violent means, Subhash Chandra Bose's grand vision for India's liberation and the idealistic organization of INA ignited unprecedented inspiration among the Indian populace.

Royal Indian Navy (RIN) Rating Mutiny (1946)

The February 18, 1946 Naval Uprising, also known as the Royal Indian Navy Mutiny, was an uprising by Indian sailors, soldiers, police officers, and civilians against the British administration in India.

Significance:

- Militancy was viewed as being expressed by the people's fearless behaviour.
- The military coup had a significant freeing impact on people's psyches.
- The RIN uprising was considered a sign of the end of British rule.
- These increases led the British to make some concessions.

Limitations:

- **Violent Nature:** Unlike earlier peaceful demonstrations of national unity, these mutinies represented violent challenges to authority.
- **Militant Participation:** Participation was limited primarily to more militant groups within the ranks.
- **Restricted Geographical Spread:** While the broader INA agitation extended to remote rural areas, these mutinies were short-lived and confined to select urban centers.
- **Organizational Communal Harmony:** The perceived communal harmony was largely organizational rather than genuine human unity, with Muslim ratings seeking guidance from the League and the Congress and Socialists representing the rest.
- **Continued British Authority:** Despite a decline in morale among the bureaucracy, the British maintained strong infrastructural capabilities to suppress dissent.

Reaction of Indian Leaders:

- **Gandhi:** In contrast to Patel and Nehru, who first accepted Socialist leader Aruna Asaf Ali's offer to visit Bombay but quickly realised "the necessity of curbing the wild outburst of violence," Gandhi was just as hostile to the rebel naval ratings.
- **Nehru:** Leaders like Nehru began to consider a peaceful "transfer of power" from British to Indian hands, to be worked out over the course of two to five years.
- **Congress:** Due to the timing and strategy of these uprisings, Congress did not formally support them. Before a large-scale movement could be started, negotiations had been a key component of the Congress strategy
- **Communist:** They backed the workers and insurgents. In addition to expanding their efforts among poor peasants and sharecroppers, they actively engaged in the riots in Bombay and Calcutta, where they had strong support among industrial workers.

Impact of Naval Mutiny on British Colonial Aspirations (UPSC 2014)

- **Unification of Cause:** The mutiny marked a significant moment where individuals from diverse backgrounds, both within the Services and on the streets, shed blood together for a common cause.
- **Confirmation of Departure:** The occurrence of the RIN Mutiny signaled a clear indication that the British intentions to leave India were imminent.
- **Core Uprising:** The mutiny originated within the heart of the British government's armed forces, which traditionally served as a stronghold in maintaining the British Empire and suppressing dissent.
- **Ripple Effect:** Following the INA Trials and the Royal Air Force uprising, the RIN Mutiny represented the culmination of mounting discontent. These preceding incidents had already stirred fervor among the Indian populace.
- **Liberation of Thought:** The mutiny's occurrence had a profound impact on liberating public discourse. The arrest of a rating for inscribing "quit India" on HMIS Talwar acted as a catalyst for the fierce uprising.
- **Broad Support:** The revolt garnered substantial backing from individuals already opposed to the British government, further solidifying its significance in challenging colonial authority.

Second World War and Aftermath

- **Strands of National Upsurge:** During the final two years of British administration, there were two main threads of the national uprising that may be distinguished:
  - **Tortuous Negotiation:** Arduous discussions between the government, Congress, and Muslim League that were progressively marred by intergroup violence and resulted in freedom and the division.
  - **Sporadic and Localised Upsurge:** A wave of nationwide strikes was episodic, localised, frequently quite militant, and led by workers, peasants, and state peoples.

British policy towards India after war:

- **Divert the Indians' attention** from their objective of sub-continental liberty, and if at all possible, divide and disintegrate them.
- By recognising the Muslim League as the exclusive voice of Indian Muslims and using the Muslim League's demand for Pakistan they succeeded in **dividing Hindu and Muslim.**
- According to **VP Menon,** Labour victory was main factor responsible for early transfer of power.
- After the war, it was **inconvenient and significantly less profitable to govern directly** over a colony in order to reap its economic benefits, but the World War did not eliminate imperialism. They were attempting to revitalise it through new ways, such as **NEO-COLONIALISM.**

Change in Government's Attitude:

- **Shift in Global Power Dynamics:** The conclusion of the War led to a significant shift in global power dynamics, with the UK losing its status as a major player, while the USA and USSR emerged as superpowers, both supportive of India's independence.
- **Understanding of Indian Needs:** The new Labour administration demonstrated a greater understanding of India's aspirations and requirements.
- **Rise of Socialist-Radical Administrations:** A wave of socialist-radical governments swept across Europe during this period, influencing British policies towards its colonies.
- **Economic Strain on Britain:** The British economy suffered severe setbacks, and the exhaustion of British soldiers further weakened the colonial power's resolve.
- **Anti-Imperialist Sentiments in Southeast Asia:** Efforts to reassert French and Dutch dominance in Southeast Asia faced strong resistance, fueled by anti-imperialist sentiments in Vietnam and Indonesia.
- **Fear of Uprisings:** Leaders were apprehensive of a resurgence of the 1942 Congress uprising, recognizing the potential for widespread disturbances including attacks on communications, agrarian unrest, labor strikes, and military discontent.
- **Inevitability of Elections:** Given the lapse of recent elections for both the Centre and provinces in 1934 and 1937 respectively, conducting new elections post-war became an unavoidable necessity.

Election of 1945

Performance of Congress

- Congress got **91 per cent of non-Muslim votes.**
- Congress captured 57 out of 102 seats in the Central Assembly.
- In the provincial elections, it got a majority in most provinces except in Bengal, Sindh and Punjab.
- The Congress majority provinces included the NWFP and Assam which were being claimed for Pakistan

Performance of Muslim League

- Muslim League got **86.6 per cent of the Muslim votes**. It captured the 30 reserved seats in the Central Assembly.
- In the provincial elections, it got a majority in Bengal and Sindh.
- Unlike in 1937, now the League clearly established itself as the dominant party among Muslims.

Significance

- The Indian National Congress emerged as the largest party.
- The League won all Muslim constituencies and hence the elections proved to be a strategic victory for Jinnah.
- The elections witnessed communal voting in contrast to the strong anti-British unity shown in various upsurges due to:
  - **Separate Electorates:** Reinforced communal divisions by ensuring only Muslims voted for Muslim candidates and Hindus for Hindu candidates.
  - **Limited franchise**: For the provinces, less than 10 per cent of the population could vote and for the Central Assembly, less than 1 per cent of the population was eligible.

Cabinet Mission (1946): Significance and Consequences

Introduction:

- The Cabinet Mission Plan was in **response to Indian political parties and representatives failing to reach an agreement,** the Cabinet Mission and Viceroy, Lord Wavell, issued a statement on May 16, 1946, which featured recommendations for the country's constitutional future.
- **Members:** The Secretary of State for India, Lord Penthick-Lawrence, the President of the Board of Trade, Sir Stafford Cripps, and the First Lord of the Admiralty, A. V. Alexander.

Plan of the Mission:

- **Three-Tier Federal Structure:** Cabinet Mission proposed a flexible federal setup with the Union, provinces, and princely states. The Union would handle foreign affairs, defence, and communications, with power to raise necessary funds. All other powers were to be vested in provinces.
- **Provincial Autonomy and Grouping:** Provinces could form groups with their own legislatures and executives, deciding jointly on provincial subjects. They could opt out of groups after the constitution was framed, but not from the Union. Groups:

  Group A – Hindu-majority provinces

  Group B – Muslim-majority provinces in the Northwest

  Group C – Bengal and Assam

  Chief Commissioner's Provinces: Delhi, Ajmer-Marwara & Coorg to join Group A; Baluchistan to join Group B.
- **Constituent Assembly Formation:** Constituent Assembly to be elected by Provincial Assemblies for drafting the Constitution. Initially, it would meet at the Union level and later divide into the three groups.

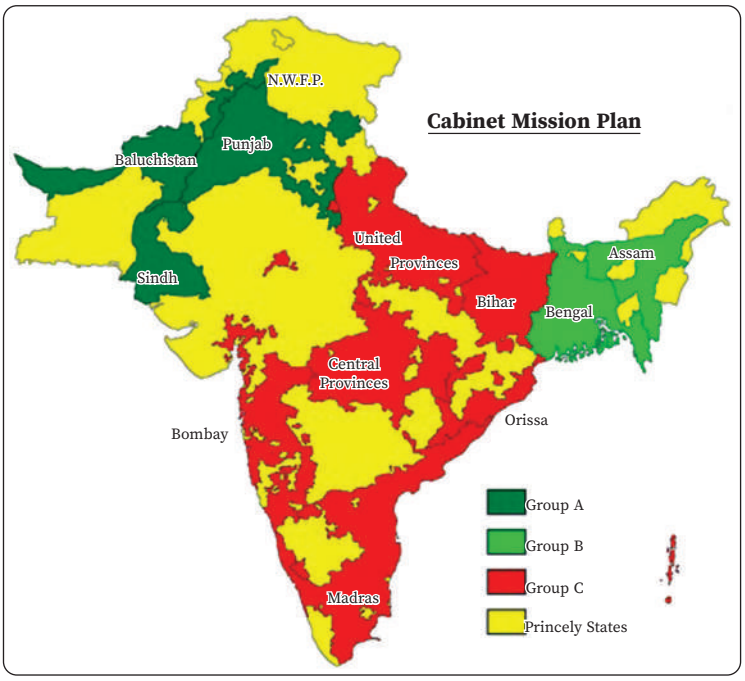

Fig. 9.2: Cabinet Mission Plan

- **Representation of Princely States:** Princely states would join the Constituent Assembly with adequate representation ensured through negotiation.
- **Ultimate Goal: Independence:** The final aim was to grant India full independence, whether inside or outside the British Commonwealth.

Significance:

- **Impact on Constituent Assembly:** Referred to as the "State Paper," the Plan significantly influenced the initial debates of the Constituent Assembly, particularly regarding federalism and Nehru's Objective Resolution.
- **Source of Legitimacy:** The Plan served as a source of legal legitimacy for the Assembly, while also leaving room for the potential inclusion of the Muslim League. Additionally, the Assembly asserted its legitimacy as derived from the Indian people rather than solely from the Plan itself.

- **Academic Importance:** The Cabinet Mission Plan is essential reading for academic research exploring various aspects of Indian constitutionalism, law, politics, and history, especially those pertaining to federalism and partition.
- **Lord Wavell's Perspective:** Lord Wavell's reflections underscore the diminishing British influence in India, highlighting the reliance on prestige and past momentum, both of which were waning.

Acceptance and Rejection

- On June 6 and June 24, 1946, respectively, the Muslim League and Congress endorsed the long-term strategy proposed by the Cabinet Mission.
- In July 1946, provincial assemblies held elections for the Constituent Assembly.
- Nehru declared on July 10, 1946, "We are not bound by anything other than the decision we have made to participate in the Constituent Assembly.
- In response to Nehru's remarks on July 29, 1946, The League withdrew its approval of the long-term strategy and issued a call for "direct action" beginning on August 16 to bring about Pakistan.

Response:

- **Muslim League:** Accepted it on the **presumption that Pakistan's premise** and foundation were built into the plan and would eventually result in Pakistan's establishment.
- **Congress:** Objected based on-
  - **Independence was a top priority**, but the Cabinet Mission said that independence would be granted following the preparation of the Constitution.
  - It objected to the **combination of Assam and the NWFP,** where a majority of the population was Muslim, with other Muslim-dominated states.
  - It demanded that the **Centre be given more authority** so that it can step in when there is a crisis or a complete collapse of the law.

Reasons for the Cabinet Mission's Failure:

- **Congress' Rejection:** The Congress party refused to accept the recommendations of the Cabinet Mission, particularly opposing the idea of dividing provinces based on religious lines and advocating for a stronger central government.
- **Introduction of Fresh Plan:** The proposal suggested the creation of separate Hindu-majority and Muslim-majority regions, along with a list of princely states given the option to join the union or remain independent.
- **Congress' Dismissal of Second Proposal:** The Congress rejected the second proposal, preferring to participate in the Constituent Assembly.
- **Muslim League's Objection:** The Muslim League objected to the nomination of Zakir Hussain by Congress, asserting its sole authority to represent Muslims and abstaining from further proceedings.
- **Direct Action Day:** On August 16, 1946, Jinnah called for "Direct Action Day," urging Muslims to demonstrate and demand Pakistan, exacerbating tensions and complicating the negotiations.

Interim Government

- **On September 2, 1946**, a Congress-dominated Interim Government led by Nehru was sworn in out of fear that Congress would take widespread action. Nehru continued to assert that his party opposed the mandatory grouping.
- Despite its name, the Interim Government amounted to little more than a continuation of the viceroy's old executive.
- **On October 26, 1946,** Wavell quietly incorporated the Muslim League into the Interim Government**.**

Mountbatten Plan (1947) or 3rd June Plan and Responses to it by Various Stakeholders

This law was passed to make provisions for the establishment of two independent Dominions in India, to replace certain provisions of the Government of India Act of 1935. This action became known as the Mountbatten Plan or the 3 June Plan.

Features:

- **Clause 1:** India and Pakistan would emerge as two independent Dominions on August 15, 1947.
- **Clause 2:** The territories of the two Dominions would be delineated after the appointment of a boundary commission. All Indian Provinces, except those constituting Pakistan, would be part of the Indian Dominion.
- **Common Governor General:** Provision was made for a single Governor General if both Dominions agreed, if not then, each dominion would have a Governor General appointed by His Majesty to represent them in their respective Governments.
- **Legislative Authority:** Each Dominion's legislature would have the power to enact laws governing its own territory.
- **Exercise of Power:** The Constituent Assembly of each Dominion would exercise all powers vested in the Dominion Legislature.
- **Secretary of Commonwealth Relations:** This office would oversee matters concerning the Dominion of India and Pakistan, ensuring coordination and communication within the Commonwealth.

Responses:

- **Gandhi and Azad:** They spoke out against the Mountbatten Plains plan for the division of India. Gandhi was extremely upset and urged people not to accept the division at face value. He rallied the populace to combat it.

- **Congress' Position:** Congress accepted the provision transferring authority to many centres because it allowed the existing assembly to proceed with drafting a constitution for the regions it represents and provided a way out of the impasse that existed at the moment.
- **Muslim League Objections:** Jinnah's intransigent demands that the League have the absolute right to select all Muslim members and that there be a form of communal veto in the Executive, with actions opposed by Muslims requiring a two-thirds majority, were the main causes of the conference's breakdown.
- **Dickie Bird Plan:** The proposal by Sardar Patel and V. P. Menon for the transfer of authority to two central governments, India and Pakistan, on the basis of grants of Dominion Status, led to Nehru's opposition to the plan and its abandonment.

The Role of British Imperial Power in Complicating the Process of Transfer of Power during the 1940s (UPSC Mains 2019)

The 1940s were the Indian National Movement's most difficult decade. British Imperial Power had moved pawns to make the transfer of power anything but a smooth process due to the necessity of seeking Indian participation in World War II.

1. August Offer:	❖ It was intended to win India's support for the war by recommending: ❖ The extension of the viceroy's executive council to include a majority of Indians and ❖ The election of an Indian-majority constituent assembly after the war. ❖ **Outcome**: The provisions of the offer were rejected by the Indians because they did not give them complete control over their government and required minorities' approval for future constitutions.
2. 1942's Cripps Mission:	❖ The mission provided rigid offers that are once again extremely unsatisfactory for the Indians and were made by an unstable coalition government of conservatives and liberals in Britain. ❖ **Outcome:** The Cripps mission's failure merely served to demonstrate that the British only sent this expedition in an effort to appear interested in Indian independence.
3. Wavell Plan and Shimla Conference, 1945:	❖ To break the impasse in India. ❖ Creation of a new Executive Council with Indians constituting the majority of its members, with the Viceroy and Commander in Chief being the sole exceptions. ❖ There were supposed to be Indian representatives in charge of every portfolio but the defence one. ❖ Muslims, who made up only approximately 25% of the population overall, were granted the privilege to be overrepresented in the 14-member Proposed Executive Council by choosing six representatives. ❖ **Outcome:** While disagreeing with the demand, Congress defended its authority to nominate representatives from any community, including Muslims, to the Council.
4. The Cabinet Mission of 1946:	❖ It sought to establish a constituent assembly and an interim administration. ❖ A mandatory grouping of provinces was the contentious aspect of the mission's suggestion. ❖ The Muslim League wanted it to be required, but Congress saw it as optional. ❖ **Outcome:** Congress subsequently rejected the offer as result, and the Muslim League further compounded matters by announcing **"direct action".**

Conclusion

The British ultimately stoked sectarian feelings with all these issues, which finally resulted in the partition of India. Thus, the 1940s ended up being a time of instability that gave rise to a new world and where the British irreversibly lost their greatness.

Key Words

Second World War, Viceroy Linlithgow, Indian Independence, Quit India Movement, August Offer, Individual Satyagraha, Cripps Mission, INA, Azad Hind Fauj, Shimla Conference, Wavell Plan, Cabinet Mission, Mountbatten Plan, Partition of India.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	What were the events that led to the Quit India Movement? Point out its results.	2024
2.	Assess the role of British imperial power in complicating the process of transfer of power during the 1940s.	2019
3.	In what ways did the naval mutiny prove to be the last nail in the coffin of British colonial aspirations in India?	2014

❖ ❖ ❖